FOR SHAKUNTALA GUPTA · 5 OCTOBER 2026 · EDITION 35

A Village Within Me

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Translation refinements for your review

Thank you for pointing out the village's feminine presence in the poem. The aim of these refinements is to carry that presence more clearly into Hindi and English while keeping the poem's intimacy, imagery and emotional movement.

For discussion: these are proposed changes, not a final translation. They have not been applied to the website.

The village as bride and beloved

Following your suggestion, this Hindi version tries टोली with feminine agreement. If it feels right, the title and other village references should be reviewed together.

Proposed Hindi stanza

मेरे न होने पर,
मेरी टोली ऐसे खिलखिलाती है,
नई बहू की तरह।
घाव और अभाव को गहना बनाकर पहनती है,
सजती है,
ईश्वर की गुप्त प्रेयसी की तरह।

Proposed English stanza

When I am not there,
my village laughs like this, bright and bubbling,
like a new bride.
She wears wounds and want as ornaments,
adorns herself
like God's secret beloved.

In English, **"She … herself"** makes the personification explicit. In Hindi, "मेरे न होने पर" leaves the speaker's gender open while the village remains feminine. The image of wounds and want as ornaments stays intact.

A VILLAGE WITHIN ME · SHAKUNTALA GUPTA

A few small refinements

These suggestions address phrasing without smoothing away the poem's distinctive images. Your sense of the voice and rhythm will guide the final choices.

HINDI · WINTER LEAVES

सर्दियों का पत्ते झरना कितना सुंदर!
Suggested: सर्दियों में पत्तों का झरना कितना सुंदर!

A more natural construction, keeping the season and image unchanged.

HINDI · MEMORY AND WOOD

पुरानी स्मृति अब पानी खाई लकड़ी है।
Suggested: पुरानी स्मृति अब पानी से गली लकड़ी है।

This reads more naturally but moves the image toward decay. Does that carry the force you intend? The English "water-eaten wood" may be worth retaining.

ENGLISH · THE INVITATION

"Whichever lane or bend you pass,"
Suggested: "Whichever lane you take, whichever bend you turn,"

A more idiomatic invitation, keeping the direct address.

Three questions for you

1. The tree, the name and the leaf

ଯେ ଯା ଗଛକୁ ତା ନାଁର ପତର!

Whose name belongs to the leaf here? Is this a local saying, or an image particular to this poem?

2. The divided measure

କିଛି ଘରେ ଭାଗ କରା ହେଇଚି ଗଉଣି,

What exactly is being divided here? The current translations use grain measures; we would like to confirm the meaning in context.

3. The speaker and the addressed "you"

Should either have a specified gender in Hindi, or should both remain open? The village's feminine presence need not determine their genders.

What we want to preserve: the village's everyday textures, its wounds and want, the mahua and kadamba trees, and the open meaning of the speaker's absence at the close.